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Telemedicine can connect doctor to patient across continents in realtime. Here's how the Apollo Telemedicine Network Foundation implements its vision

Ram Mohan Rao

We travelled frequently to Hyderabad to consult Dr R G about a kidney problem that my father suffers from. We no longer need to. Thanks to telemedicine, we were able to get him to examine my father, and prescribe medication, in Eluru itself. This facility saves money and time. I am grateful to Apollo." That letter, dated August 5, 2004, was from a certain P J in Eluru, Andhra Pradesh. For this patient, as well as for thousands of others—including a 32-year-old Pakistani woman diagnosed as suffering from a brain tumour—Apollo Hospital's telemedicine links are a godsend.

The Pakistani woman received expert advice from radiation

oncologists through the link. Dr S Hukku, senior radiation oncologist at Apollo Hospital, saved her the trouble of travelling to Delhi by dispensing advice on the line of treatment to the Apollo telemedicine centre in Lahore. This centre utilises Internet connectivity of 128-256 KBps to access Medintegra Web, a telemedicine software, and full-screen videoconferencing as well. Dr Hukku later told the *Tribune News Service* that Apollo had been treating cancer patients from Bangladesh, Pakistan, Sri Lanka and West Asia. "Most of the cases are of brain tumour. They opt for treatment in India because neurosurgery is well developed

here," he said. Dr Hukku said that if the patient from Pakistan had to come to Apollo, instead of being treated via telemedicine, she would have to pay anything between Rs 1 to 1.5 lakh for surgery.

Dr Puneet Gupta, another cancer specialist at Indraprastha Apollo Hospital, told the *Tribune News Service* that the telemedicine link between Delhi and Lahore would "change the standard of cancer care in (Pakistan)."

Apollo has 62 telemedicine centres in India and has telemed-

